

Kenya Country Programs Strategy

Kenyan youth, particularly **young women from marginalized and vulnerable regions** are harnessing **sustainable and resilient market opportunities** and shaping the future of work to ensure **inclusive access to dignified and fulfilling work** for all

7 Mn

Youth in D&F work through 75% Africa-led organisations

70%

Young women (5Mn), in D&F work

5%

PWD, and 1% refugees in D&F work

30+ %

All youth in Kenya impacted by 2030

KES 100 bn

Potential GDP impact from new MSMEs & jobs

1 Mn+

Youth SMEs supported by portfolio

1

Catalyse young women entrepreneurship at scale

Ensure wholistic programming around her
Enable access to affordable finance and tailored products; and facilitate linkages to markets.

2

Develop workforce for the future of work

Create equitable access for marginalized young people; Support demand-led skilling and link to market opportunities.

3

Leveraging Kenya's strengths

Leverage Kenya's unique strengths in the digital and green economy, to enable young people access work opportunities, through innovative programming and partnerships.

Shift the ecosystem sustainably

Proactively leverage thought leadership and Foundation's convening role, building on our strategic priorities, to make systemic changes to the ecosystem beyond our partners.

Implement young women-, digital-, and green-first interventions across all programs

Results to date

As of January 2026, we have enabled 4.3M young people in Kenya to access work, of which 50% are young women. 15.8M young participated in work-enabling activities, out of which 56% were young women.

Partnerships

64 Approved Partners

64% (41) Active Partners

66% (44) African-led

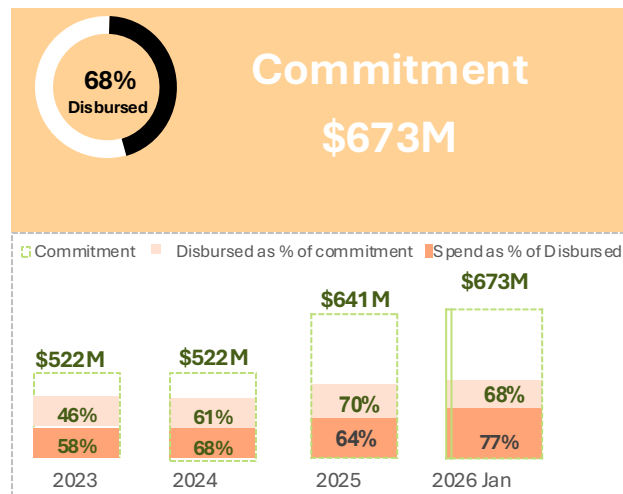
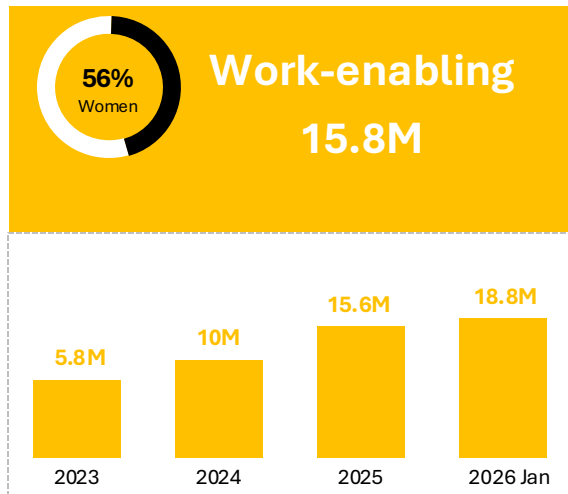
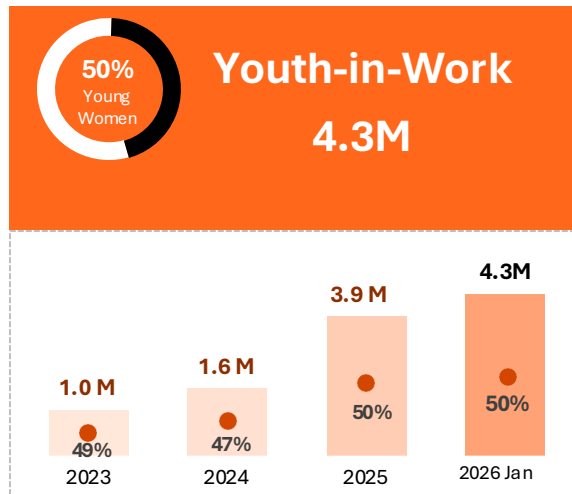


98 Programs

7 Pipeline

7 ending in 2026

(EGF, KEPSA, Emobilis, CiCAN, Moringa, KCBF, FAWE)



Note:

- Work-enabling outreach: Mainly driven by skilling activities.
- Between October 2025 and Jan 2026, there has been a net new YiW of 400K against a stagnant WoE outreach number; this shows a good direction in deepening impact. Need to program with the D&F work as the final outcome, not just youth in work.



Module 1

Introduction to Young Women Centered (YWC) Approach

Participant Toolkit Objective

This participant toolkit is divided into two parts, which combine to help achieve a single objective.

The objective is to enable you to scale young women in dignified and fulfilling work results using the Young-Women Centered Design (YWCD) approach.

The YWCD approach centers the aspirations and needs of the young women participants. It is applied throughout the program cycle— design, implementation and evaluation.

Note: links to 1-2 minutes public videos that are not Foundation property are included in the kit.

Module 1 Content

In this module, you will get to have a deeper understanding on the:

- Young Women-Centered Design (YWCD) approach
- Young Women-Centered (YWC) Mindsets
- Young Women-Centered (YWC) Process

This module will launch your journey on becoming even more young women centered by helping you to :

- Understand your programs Personas
- Reflect on your Problem Statement

Young Women have very different lived realities

Young women are not a homogeneous group;

- They may have different starting points
- They might have different levels of participation, agency, capability
- They might have different resources.

Understanding these different lived realities is crucial to reaching our goal. This is why we must use a Young Women Centered Design (YWCD) approach.

Tip: The illustrations on slide (6) at any time to familiarise yourself with what matters when we are designing for young women.

We are designing to accelerate and scale the journey of marginalized young women to dignified and fulfilling work

Starting point

Choiceless
choices



Participation

Chance to attend/ enroll
Increase awareness,
knowledge



Capability

Improved capacity,
skills, resources



Choice

Expanded options/
opportunities



Agency/Power

Impact at breadth &
scale

Young Woman Centered Programming



Time
(Care)

Physical Assets
(Equipment/Land)

Safety
(Safeguarding & Mobility)

Networks & Shifting Norms
(community & industry)

Introduction: Young Women Centered Design approach

The YWCD approach builds on Human-Centered Design (HCD)* principles. It is a **problem-solving approach** that prioritizes the **needs, behaviors, and emotions of young women**.

It's about creating solutions that **truly resonate with and benefit the young women we serve**.

It requires us to **empathize to ensure that program designs solve** problems in a way that enhances and **sustains young women's success**.



Young Women Centered Design Approach

Young Women Centered Approach is both a Mindset & a Process

MINDSET

ALL problems, no matter how complex, can be solved. Yet not all problems can be solved in the same way.

The YWCD approach requires an innovative way of thinking. It requires us to devolve power, center the user and practice empathy to gain a deeper understanding of the young women we serve.

PROCESS

The YWCD approach is defined as a creative problem-solving technique. It starts and ends with empathy and a deep understanding of young women's perspectives and realities. The process aims to create lasting demand-based solutions.

YWCD Mindsets



The YWC Mindsets

01

Empathy

02

Creative confidence



03

Embracing Ambiguity



Please watch this video on empathy vs sympathy



Empathy

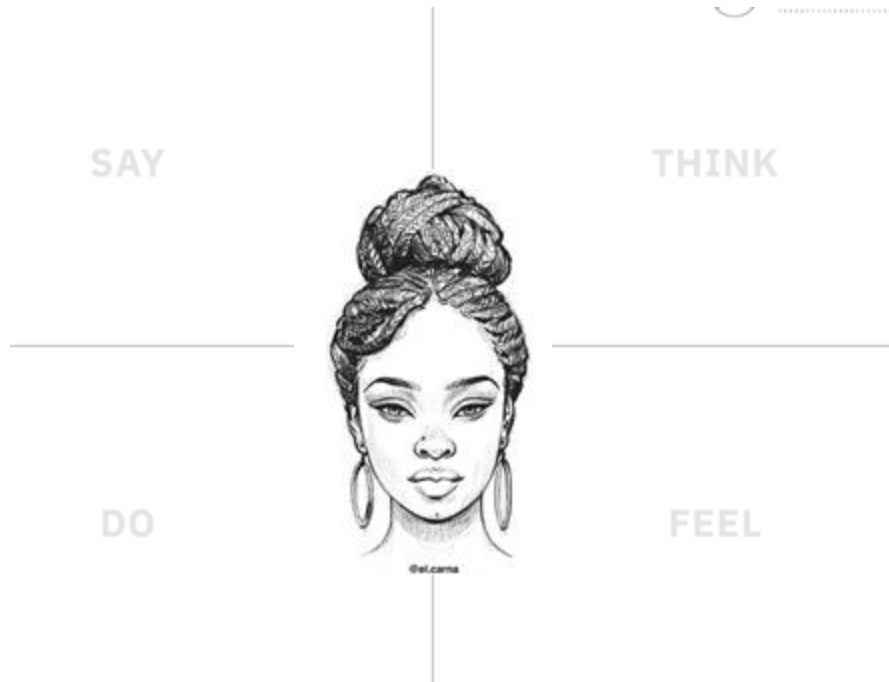
Empathy is very different from sympathy. It empowers the participant and the designer to develop effective solutions.

Empathy is the **practiced ability** to unlearn perceived experiences, contexts, challenges and opportunities in order to relearn them from the user's perspective.

Empathy is an exercise in active listening, beyond the simple words of the user and encompassing their thoughts, actions and feelings.

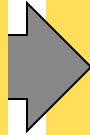
While exercised in group settings, empathy encourages acknowledging heterogeneity of users. It is mindful that all experiences are not the same and thrives on constructive differences.

Finally, empathy extends beyond the user. It requires users to attend to user's contexts including the influences of interpersonal relationships, contextual barriers, social determiners and etc...



Reflections: Empathy vs Sympathy

Reflect on the difference between empathy and sympathy



- Think about a time when empathy got you further towards a solution than sympathy?
- If you can NOT think of one, empathy may be a muscle to build.



You can write your thoughts down

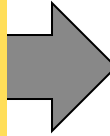
Exercise: Practicing Empathy in Programs

Classify your question.
Was it a sympathy or an empathy question?

Sympathy perspective

How can I help?

- Feels pity or sorrow for someone else who is experiencing misfortune and want to retain power to help
- It is about what I am experiencing as an individual in relation to the situation
- It is more about you, not about the other person.



Empathy perspective

What do they need?

- Connects emotionally and takes on the other's perspective
- It is about listening and the other person's feelings, thoughts, and what they want to do about the situation of another,
- It is more focused the other person and empowering them

Applying Empathy in Programs

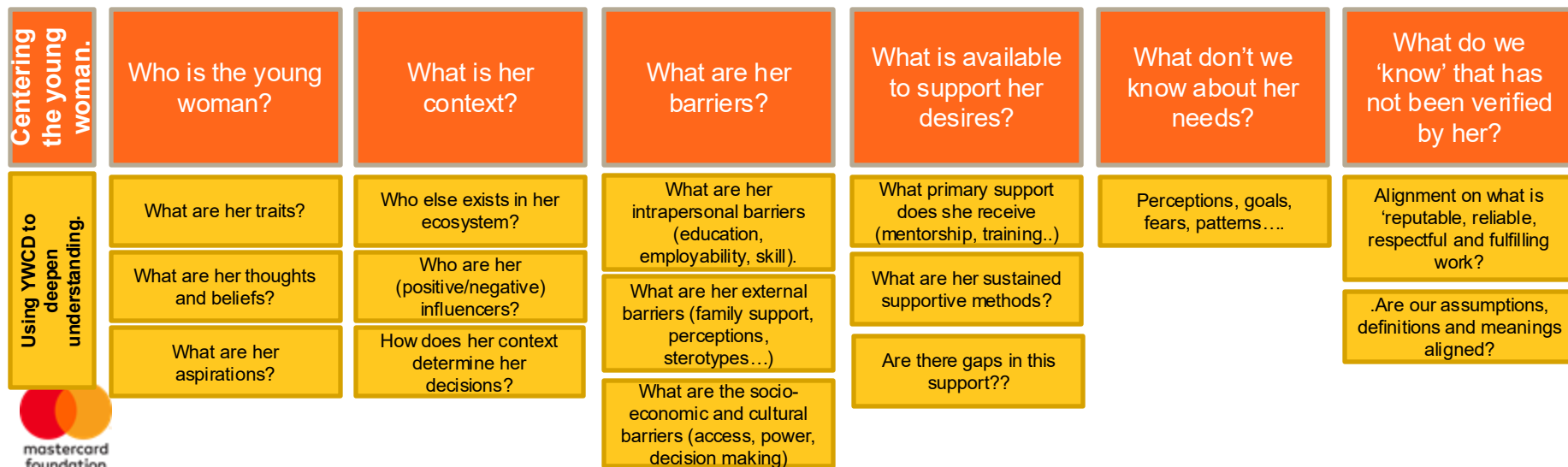
1. It is important that programming start with empathy to understand the problem and needs
2. Think about how well you practice empathy in program design and implementation?
3. We will cover the process of practicing empathy in subsequent slides

Step 1: Empathizing with the Young Woman

Compile what you know about your participant to identify the gaps in your knowledge of her.
Empathizing is about problematizing from her perspective, which is likely very different from yours.

These are the questions you could ask yourself when immersing yourself in her reality and perspective.

Primary Goal: Young women have access to reputable work that generates reliable income while fulfilling her sense of purpose and respect in the work place.



Creative Confidence

Creativity is not a special talent. Anyone can become a designer as long as they commit to thinking outside the box.

Designers are focused on solving the problem and not tied to one idea.

Designers think outside the box. They believe the 'impossible' is 'possible'.

Creative confidence is progressive. Keep at it, and you will amaze yourself and others.



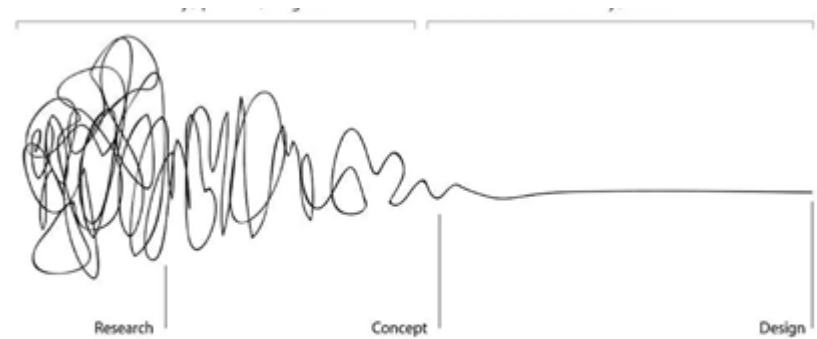
Embracing Ambiguity

Ambiguity and failure is part of the design process.

Most problems are complex. Similarly, the HCD process is complex in its cyclical application. This means that HCD is not linear and all progressions may not be applied as they appear.

That is why it is important to try, fail, iterate and try again. Designers are always testing, gaining feedback and integrating feedback into their designs.

Embracing ambiguity requires open mindedness. One way to look at 'failure' is as an opportunity for improvement.



Exercise : the ambiguity map

What concerns you most about using the Young Women Centered Approach? Map these fears.



Write your fears here

Reflection: the ambiguity map

What can you do to grow more comfortable with fears about using the Young Women Centered Approach?

- a.
- b.
- c.
- d.
- e.

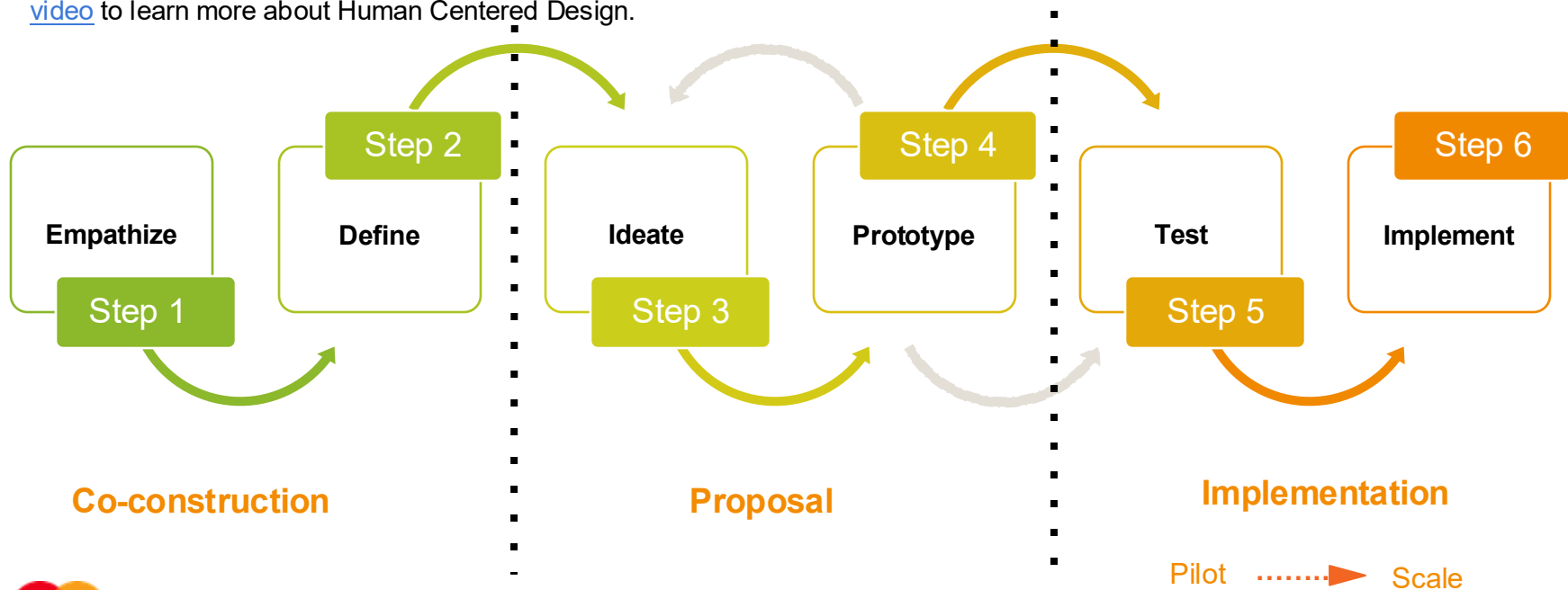
These tactics will help you embrace ambiguity.

YWCD Process



Six Iterative Steps

The design process is iterative and non-linear. These are six key steps part of the design process. You can watch [this video](#) to learn more about Human Centered Design.



Process

1. Empathize

The first step is to develop a deep understanding of the target young women in their context. You can use a **persona**.

Give her a name for example:
Amina (coastal),
Mukali (informal),
Naserian (pastoral)

Ask yourself:

- What are her biggest needs?
- What are her barriers?
- What has she tried?
- What has worked for her?

2. Define

Problem statement should be captured from the perspective of young women rather than focused on program goals.

- 1) What is the problem?
- 2) Who else does the problem effect?
- 3) Where is the problem?
- 4) Why does it matter to the young woman

3. Ideate

Now that the problem you intend to solve is clear, it's time to brainstorm ways to address the problem.

Include young women you intend to serve.

Collect as many ideas as possible, so you can evaluate them at the end and prioritize

Ideation ends with decisions on which idea/s to take forward.

Process

4. Prototype

Prototyping is where teams turn their many ideas into few tangible concepts that are ready to be run past young women and key stakeholders

5. Testing

Testing with real users often called piloting or proof of concept.

Refining one concept response to young women's feedback. Requires constant young women led improvement and refinement.

6. Implementation

Implementation is where teams scale proven concept into larger scale programmatic intervention.

This requires thinking about

- Impact
- Sustainability
- Feasibility
- Scalability

Empathizing is about busting our own stereotypes

Click on the [link](#) or the triangle below to watch the video.



Reflection: What stereotypes did the video bust for you?

You can write your thoughts down below



Developing Personas

The first step in developing a persona is centering her voice.

01.

The Who

Who is doing the research and who is participating?

02.

The What

What are focusing on / what are we hoping to learn and solve?

03.

The Why

How are we ensuring that young women secure dignified and fulfilling work?

The who

Who are the young women you are designing with & for?

- Beyond their gender, women have other backgrounds & identities that affects their human experience.
- For example:
 - Where they live
 - If they have children
 - How much education they have been able to receive
 - Etc...



Rural family woman



Rural single woman



Peri-urban educated woman



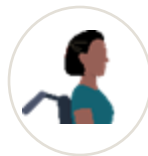
Urban family woman



Urban single woman



Urban educated woman



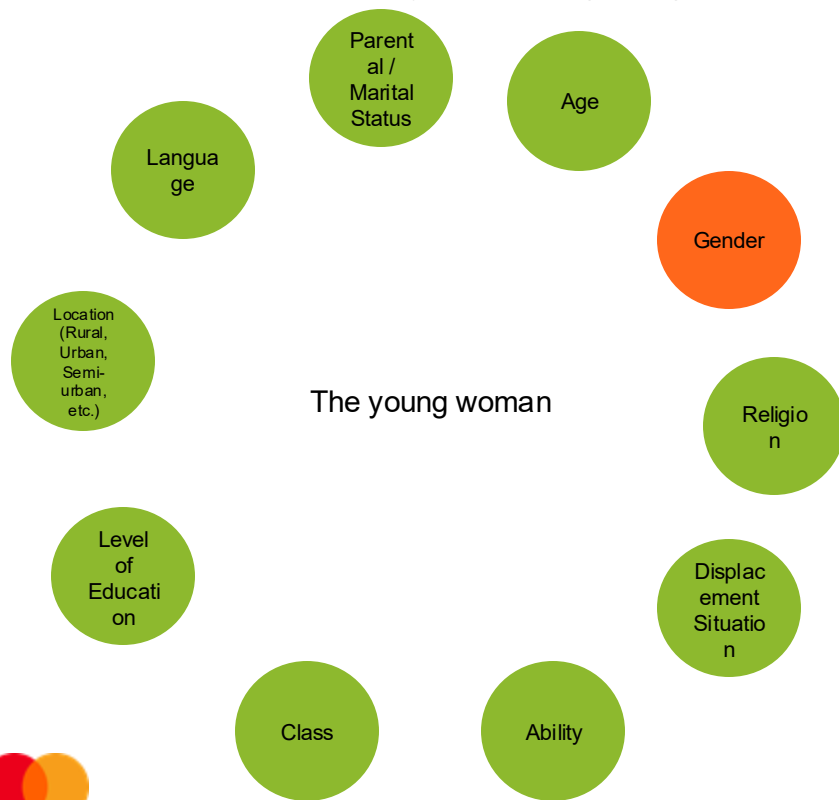
Woman with disability



Displaced woman

Examples of different young women personas

Exercise: Who are you designing for



Exercise (on the next slide)

List the identities of the young women you are hoping to serve with your program. Example below

Category	Who is the young woman you are hoping to serve?
Gender	Female
Age groups	16-21, 21-24
Parental and/or Marital Status	Single Mothers
Level of Education	All levels
Location	Rural, Semi-Urban
Displacement status	...
Religion	...
Class	...
Ability	...
Languages	...
<Additional category>	...
<Additional category>	...

Your Personas

Use the previous exercise to write down your persona/s.

Persona Example

- ❖ **Name:** Amina
- ❖ **Demographics:** Age 18, married, mother of 2 living in a small village near Watamu.
- ❖ **Education:** High school graduate, limited work experience
- ❖ **Challenge:** Wants to start a small business, but lacks access to training, funding, and networks.
- ❖ **Economics:** Amina is a small business owner engaged in coconut retail (the business has 1 male youth employee). Her husband works part-time carving curios for tourist shops.
- ❖ **Social:** Amina is a member of a chama of local female entrepreneurs.

Create your Personas

Persona 1

- ❖ Name:
- ❖ Demographics:
- ❖ Education:
- ❖ Challenge:
- ❖ Economics:
- ❖ Social:

Persona 2

- ❖ Name:
- ❖ Demographics:
- ❖ Education:
- ❖ Challenge:
- ❖ Economics:
- ❖ Social:

Persona 3

- ❖ Name:
- ❖ Demographics:
- ❖ Education:
- ❖ Challenge:
- ❖ Economics:
- ❖ Social:

STEP 2: DEFINE

We cannot design for young women without centering their voices. What does that look like?

01.

The Who

Who is doing the research and who is participating?

02.

The What

What are focusing on / what are we hoping to learn and solve?

03.

The Why

How are we ensuring that young women secure dignified and fulfilling work?

Step 2: Define the Problem (The What)

Now that we understand the Persona/s, let's think through the problem we are solving.



Rural family woman



Rural single woman



Peri-urban educated woman



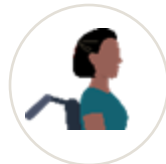
Urban family woman



Urban single woman



Urban educated woman



Woman with disability



Displaced woman

YWCD Problem Framing

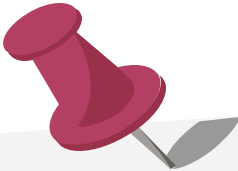


The Problem

Reflect on the questions below



***Are we solving
the right
problem? Do
we understand
the context?***



***Does it reflect
the needs of the
young women
we are hoping to
serve?***

Getting to a good program starts with...

Understanding the lived experience of young women in work

What are
their hopes,
desires,
aspirations?

What are
their most
pressing
needs?

What are
their barriers
to entry and
to staying in
work?

**You made it
through
Module 1!!**

